regime security, others to protect their technology leads or way of life, and still more who would like to limit exposure and build capabilities for themselves. These new forms of competition are likely to be among the fundamental characteristics of the politics of our era. Our globalized world is likely to be fractured in some respects and even selectively disengaged in areas of particular contention. These are some of the inevitabilities for which India needs to plan intelligently.

REFRESHING ANALYSIS AND POLICY

Such examples may reflect more recent trends, but we cannot forget that old-fashioned national rivalry also continues to be very much at play. Especially after 2008, the world has seen a sharper re-balancing and the steady emergence of multipolarity. The shifting terms of the US engagement with it in the last decade is a key dimension. The ending of a ‘forever war’ in Afghanistan only heralded different ways of ensuring American security and furthering US interests. But the manner in which it did may have signalled weakness of a kind that was not intended. That, too, is going through a process of correction.

The rise of China is an equally profound happening, one whose global consequences are becoming more apparent. That so much of it is taking place outside established constructs is clearly conceptually challenging for both policymakers and analysts. Far from being a zero-sum game, these developments have also opened up space for other players, some essentially regional and others with greater potential. Clearly, the world perceives India to be in the latter category. As all of this is unfolding, the Ukraine conflict has reminded us of the importance of Russia while underlining the strategic mobilization of Europe. If this matrix already looks complicated, then the volatility is further compounded by the impact on the developing world of a range of economic challenges. Throw in a whole lot of pre-existing and neglected problems. As a result, the world as a whole is staring at a far more uncertain and insecure future.

Such a prospect clearly calls for greater diplomatic energies and political creativity. It is even more necessary now to harmonize the pursuit of national interest with a responsibility for collective good. For a nation like India, where such a large segment of its population is so vulnerable, it means, first of all, to mitigate the impact of key negative trends. In doing